

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Reuters

Sir Keir Starmer insisted he would “get on with governing” even though more than 80 Labour MPs called for him to quit as prime minister. Miatta Fahnbulleh, a minister, and four junior members of Sir Keir’s government resigned in the past day. The Labour Party was trounced in local elections last week. The crisis has rattled bond markets; 30-year gilt yields hit their highest level since 1998.

Donald Trump warned that the ceasefire with **Iran** is “on massive life support”. He called Iran’s response to **America’s** peace plan “garbage” and said he did not finish reading it. Earlier Iran defended its counter-proposal, which includes ending **America’s blockade** of its ports, and said discussions about its nuclear programme would happen “when the time is right”. The price of Brent crude, the international oil benchmark, rose to around \$105 a barrel.

American business leaders including Elon Musk, Tesla’s boss, and Tim Cook, the head of Apple, will reportedly accompany Mr Trump on his trip to **China** this week. The president hopes his **high-stakes summit** with Xi Jinping, China’s leader, will result in new business deals following a stalemate in the countries’ bitter trade war.

Scott Bessent, America's treasury secretary, arrived in Tokyo for talks with **Japanese** officials. Katayama Satsuki, the country's finance minister, said that her government is co-ordinating with America on "market moves, including exchange rates". Japan is thought to have spent nearly ¥10trn (\$63.5bn) recently to prop up the [yen](#), its weak currency. Mr Bessent is expected to join Mr Trump in China.

Emmanuel Macron unveiled a €23bn (\$27bn) investment package to create 250,000 jobs across **Africa** and **France**, targeting sectors such as artificial intelligence, agriculture and the energy transition. The French president made the announcement at a summit in Kenya, which has been widely interpreted as an attempt to renew France's ties with the continent. Its influence has diminished in recent years, particularly in the Sahel, where several countries have expelled French military forces.

The remaining crew and passengers aboard the *MV Hondius*, a cruise ship hit by an outbreak of **hantavirus**, left the vessel. The World Health Organization has so far confirmed 11 cases of the [rodent-borne virus](#), including a Spanish national who was evacuated on Sunday. Three people have died. The UN agency said there is "no sign" of a larger outbreak.

Wordle, a popular [mobile puzzle game](#) published by the *New York Times*, will be turned into a television show for NBC, an American network. The series will be filmed in Britain and is expected to air next year. Millions of people are thought to play the game, which the *Times* acquired for an undisclosed seven-figure sum in 2022.

Figure of the day: 15%, the share of global tantalum supplied by Rubaya, a town northwest of Goma in the Democratic Republic of Congo. [Read why](#) M23, a Congolese militia, wants to sell critical minerals to Donald Trump.



Photograph: Getty Images

America's coming grocery-price shock

How expensive could [American groceries](#) get? The first big clue will come on Tuesday, with the publication of consumer-price index data for April. Food prices are already a third higher than they were before the covid-19 pandemic.

The energy-price shock from the Iran war is reverberating through supply chains. [Farmers](#) face much steeper fertiliser and fuel costs. Donald Trump's tariffs are also making imports pricier; tomatoes, which America mostly imports from Mexico, cost almost 25% more than they did a year ago.

But the greatest pressure on prices may come from the next two stages of the supply chain: packaging and transport, which rely on oil. The soaring cost of plastic, derived from fossil fuels, will mainly impact prices of the thickly wrapped products in the home-care and beauty aisles. Transport accounts for as much as half of the supply chain's oil consumption. Americans may find the knock-on effects hard to stomach.



Photograph: Office of the Secretary of War Public Affairs

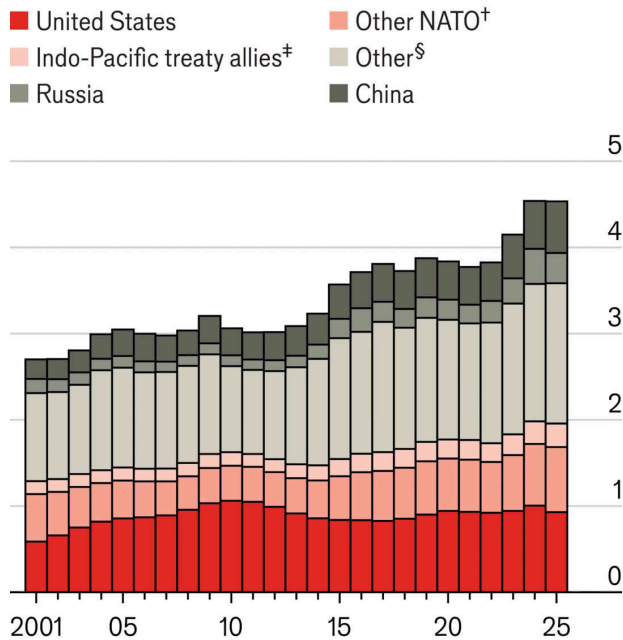
The global arms race

On Tuesday Pete Hegseth, America's secretary of war, will appear before a Senate committee to defend the administration's proposal to raise Pentagon spending by more than 40%, to around \$1.5trn in 2027. The record request will face a difficult path through Congress, where Democrats and fiscal conservatives alike are sceptical. The war in Iran has further complicated matters. During a similar hearing in the House of Representatives last month, Democrats spent hours grilling Mr Hegseth over the conflict, which has so far cost America at least \$25bn.

America is not the only country spending more on arms. In real terms, global military expenditure rose for the 11th straight year in 2025, according to [our annual ranking](#), based on data from SIPRI, a think-tank. European countries, seeking to reduce their reliance on America, accounted for more than half the increase. Indeed, by one measure America's principal allies collectively outspent it in 2025. If Mr Hegseth gets his way, America could soon reclaim the lead.

On target

Military spending at military purchasing-power parity*, \$trn, 2024 prices



*Adjusting spending to reflect cost and wage differences with the United States

[†]Membership at 2025. Excluding United States

[‡]Australia, Japan, South Korea, Thailand and the Philippines

[§]Does not include all countries as estimates

for some are unavailable, notably North Korea

Sources: SIPRI; P. Robertson, The University of

Western Australia; *The Economist*



Photograph: Getty Images

Samsung faces its unions

On Tuesday Samsung Electronics will aim to conclude negotiations with workers to avert a strike. Unions want the South Korean tech champion to remove caps on bonuses; they are also demanding that 15% of operating profits be paid to chip-division employees every year—worth around \$34bn, based on projections for 2026. If no deal is reached, nearly 40,000 workers will begin an 18-day strike next week, hurting the firm's growing semiconductor business.

A walkout on this scale would be sorely felt in South Korea's wider economy. The company's valuation soared past the \$1trn mark earlier this month thanks to voracious demand for its artificial-intelligence memory chips. That sent the country's benchmark index, the KOSPI, to a record high. South Korea's stock market is now the world's seventh largest. Given its giddy ascent, one wobble could bring it down.



Photograph: Getty Images

America keeps an eye on the Bahamas

Philip Davis, the Bahamas' prime minister and leader of the populist Progressive Liberal Party, is seeking re-election on Tuesday. The election will be closely watched by American officials, who are observing it after the opposition leader, Michael Pintard, voiced concerns over voter fraud.

America was already displeased with the Caribbean country, which lies about 50 miles from Florida. Its ambassador has publicly criticised the archipelago for borrowing \$285m of Chinese money to build a state-of-the-art hospital. Chinese firms also operate two of its major ports. That irks Donald Trump, who is trying to reassert American influence in the region.

Mr Davis has tried to mollify the Trump administration. Last year, he promised to renegotiate a health-care agreement with Cuba that had drawn America's ire. And ahead of the election he hired Roger Stone, a political adviser pardoned by Mr Trump, and C.J. Pearson, a MAGA influencer, to help "build stronger relations" with America. More such manoeuvres may be needed before long.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which American president was born in a town called Hope?

Monday: Which Renaissance artist had a sideline as a military engineer for Cesare Borgia?

Calm and order can be just as dangerous to democracy as uneasiness and disorder.

Hildegard Hamm-Brücher